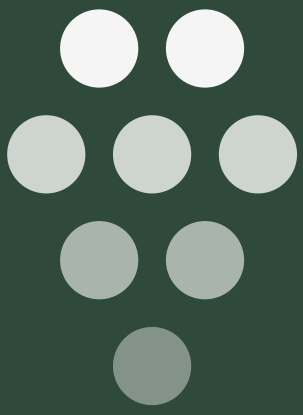
MICHAEL CHERNYAKOV · COACHING

FREE STUDY GUIDE

ICF ACC Exam Study Guide

Definitions, the Code of Ethics, the eight Core Competencies and the answer rules that decide the hard questions.



Independent study aid based on ICF's published Code of Ethics and Core Competencies. Not produced or endorsed by ICF.

BEFORE YOU START

How to use this guide

Everything I needed for the ICF ACC knowledge exam on one set of pages — the definitions, the Code of Ethics, the eight Core Competencies, and the patterns that decide between two good-looking answers.

Work through it once from the front, then use the tables, memory aids and the answer rules in section 11 for revision. The **exam angle** notes and **wrong-answer patterns** are my own summaries of how questions tend to be framed.

01 The exam at a glance

02 What coaching is, and what it is not

03 ICF Code of Ethics (2020)

04 The 28 Ethical Standards

05 The situations the exam loves

06 The 8 Core Competencies (2019)

07 Competency borders: which one is it?

08 Agreements, goal setting and motivation

09 Models, tools and techniques

10 Glossary A–Z

11 Answer rules and common mistakes

WHICH CODE OF ETHICS?

ICF introduced a new Code of Ethics that took effect on 1 April 2025 (24 standards in five sections). At the time of writing, ICF states that the ACC, PCC and MCC exams are still based on the **2020 Code**, which is what sections 3 and 4 cover in detail. The end of section 4 maps the 2020 standards onto the five themes of the 2025 Code. Always check the current position at coachingfederation.org before you sit the exam.

CREDIT

This guide is built on the **ICF Code of Ethics** (2020 and 2025) and the **ICF Core Competencies** (2019). ICF's definitions, Code wording and competency markers are © International Coaching Federation and are reproduced for study purposes with credit. The official documents are free at coachingfederation.org.

This is an independent study aid. It is not produced, reviewed or endorsed by ICF.

SECTION 1 · THE EXAM

The exam at a glance

The ICF Credentialing Exam has three domains. Knowing the weighting tells you where to spend your study time.

DOMAIN	WEIGHT	APPROX. QUESTIONS	COVERS
Coaching Competencies, Strategies and Techniques	40%	24	Agreements and contracting, the 8 Core Competencies, goal setting, motivation, tools and techniques
Coaching Ethics	30%	18	Code of Ethics, conflicts of interest, confidentiality and when it can be broken
Definition and Boundaries of Coaching	30%	18	Definition of coaching, coaching vs. other professions, referral, recognizing mental health signs

SECTION 2 · FOUNDATIONS

What coaching is, and what it is not

ICF defines coaching as:

ICF DEFINITION OF COACHING

> "Partnering with clients in a thought-provoking and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential."

Learn this sentence by heart; the key words are *partnering*, *thought-provoking*, *creative* and *maximize potential*.

Beliefs behind the definition

- The client is the expert on their own life and work; the client is creative, resourceful and whole.
- The coach doesn't fix, advise or diagnose. The coach draws out the client's own thinking.
- The client sets the agenda and is responsible for their choices and results.
- The relationship is a partnership of equals, built on agreements.
- Coaching is forward-focused: from where the client is now toward what they want.

Coaching compared with related professions

PROFESSION	FOCUS	WHO IS THE EXPERT	TIME ORIENTATION	KEY DIFFERENCE FROM COACHING
Coaching	Client's goals, awareness, action	Client	Present → future	Partnership; client finds own answers
Therapy / psychotherapy	Healing, mental health, past wounds, diagnosis	Therapist	Past → present	Treats dysfunction; licensed; diagnoses
Counseling	Resolving problems, emotional difficulties	Counselor	Past and present	Often clinical; works on distress
Mentoring	Passing on experience in a field	Mentor	Present	Mentor shares own knowledge and advice
Consulting	Solving a business problem	Consultant	Present	Consultant diagnoses and recommends solutions
Training	Building a defined skill or body of knowledge	Trainer	Present	Fixed curriculum set by the trainer
Advising	Giving expert recommendations	Advisor	Present	Tells the client what to do

> EXAM RULE
>
> If an answer has the coach diagnosing, prescribing, advising, teaching or healing, it is crossing into another profession. The exception: when the client needs expertise the coach doesn't have, the right move is to **refer**, not to redirect the client inward.

Coaching approaches you may see named

- **Executive / leadership coaching:** leaders in organizations, often with a sponsor and three-way agreement.
- **Life coaching:** whole-person goals (career change, relationships, wellbeing, purpose); client usually also pays.
- **Career, wellness/health, relationship, team and group coaching:** same competencies, different topic.
- **Internal coaching:** a coach employed by the organization coaching its staff (watch conflicts of interest).
- **Team coaching:** coaching a team as a system toward a shared goal; **group coaching:** individuals working on their own goals in a group setting.

SECTION 3 · ETHICS

ICF Code of Ethics (2020)

Structure, definitions and values.

The 2020 Code has **five parts** and **28 Ethical Standards** in four sections. It applies whenever someone represents themselves as an ICF Professional in a coaching-related interaction, whether or not a coaching relationship exists.

The five parts

1. **Introduction** – purpose of the Code and who it applies to.
2. **Key Definitions** – the terms used in the Code.
3. **ICF Core Values and Ethical Principles** – the values the standards rest on.
4. **Ethical Standards** – 28 enforceable standards in 4 sections.
5. **Pledge** – the professional's commitment; breaches can lead to sanctions.

Who is bound by the Code

- All **ICF Professionals**: coaches, coach supervisors, mentor coaches, coach trainers and **students of coaching / coaches-in-training**.
- ICF Leadership (volunteers) and the coach's **Support Personnel** (via standard 15).
- ICF Staff commit to the values, but the Ethical Conduct Review process and the Pledge apply only to ICF Professionals.
- It applies to members **and** credential holders, whether or not they are coaching at that moment.

Key definitions (Part Two)

TERM	MEANING IN THE CODE
Client	The individual or team/group being coached, the coach being mentored or supervised, or the coach or student coach being trained
Coaching	Partnering with Clients in a thought-provoking and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential
Coaching Relationship	A relationship established by the ICF Professional and the Client(s)/Sponsor(s) under an agreement or contract defining each party's responsibilities and expectations
Code of Ethics	The core values, principles and standards of behavior for all ICF Professionals
Confidentiality	Protection of any information obtained around the coaching engagement unless consent to release is given
Conflict of Interest	A situation in which an ICF Professional is involved in multiple interests, where serving one could work against or be in conflict with another; may be financial, personal or otherwise

TERM	MEANING IN THE CODE
Equality	All people experience inclusion, access to resources and opportunity, regardless of race, ethnicity, national origin, color, gender, sexual orientation, gender identity, age, religion, immigration status, mental or physical disability, and other areas of human difference
ICF Professional	Individuals who represent themselves as an ICF Member or ICF Credential-holder, in roles including Coach, Coach Supervisor, Mentor Coach, Coach Trainer and Student of Coaching
ICF Staff	ICF support personnel contracted by the managing company that provides professional management and administrative services for ICF
Internal Coach	An individual employed within an organization who coaches either part-time or full-time the employees of that organization
Sponsor	The entity (including its representatives) paying for and/or arranging or defining the coaching services
Support Personnel	People who work for ICF Professionals in support of their Clients
Systemic Equality	Gender, racial and other forms of equality institutionalized in the ethics, core values, policies, structures and cultures of communities, organizations, nations and society

Definitions follow the wording of the ICF Code of Ethics (2020).

> WATCH THE CLIENT–SPONSOR SPLIT
>
> The client is the person coached; the sponsor pays for or arranges the coaching. They can be the same person (most life coaching) or different (most organizational coaching). Their interests can differ, which is why agreements and confidentiality terms must be clear with both.

The four Core Values

All four are equally important, mutually supportive and aspirational.

> MEMORY AID
>
> **P-C-H-E — "Professional Coaches Honor Everyone"**

VALUE	CORE MEANING	IN PRACTICE
Professionalism	A commitment to a coaching mindset and professional quality that encompasses responsibility, respect, integrity, competence and excellence	Being true and accurate in statements; lifelong learning; delivering on commitments; responding to ethical dilemmas by the Code; respect and transparency in business dealings; clear and accurate representation; honesty, courage and consistency

VALUE	CORE MEANING	IN PRACTICE
Collaboration	A commitment to developing social connection and community building	Partnering within and across social-identity groups; cooperating with other ICF professionals working with the same clients or sponsors; partnering with related professions and organizations
Humanity	A commitment to being humane, kind, compassionate and respectful towards others	Accepting imperfection; openness to other views; authentic, honest relationships; ongoing self-awareness; owning mistakes; modesty; avoiding any sense of superiority; committing to inclusivity, dignity and human rights
Equity	A commitment to using a coaching mindset to explore and understand the needs of others, practicing equitable processes that create equality for all	Respecting all identity groups; equal dignity and fairness; awareness of conscious and unconscious bias in self and others; awareness of systemic equality and oppression; equality and partnership in coach–client, trainer–student, mentor–coach and supervisor–coach relationships

The Pledge (Part Five)

By taking the pledge, an ICF Professional agrees to honor their ethical and legal obligations to clients, sponsors, colleagues and the public. A breach can lead ICF to hold them accountable through the **Ethical Conduct Review (ECR)** process. Sanctions can include mandatory additional coach training or other education, and loss of ICF Membership and/or ICF Credentials.

SECTION 4 · ETHICS

The 28 Ethical Standards

The standards are grouped into four responsibilities: to **Clients** (1–13), to **Practice and Performance** (14–19), to **Professionalism** (20–24) and to **Society** (25–28). Each line below gives the standard in plain words and the angle exam questions usually take.

Section I – Responsibility to Clients (1–13)

#	THE STANDARD	EXAM ANGLE
1	Before or at the first meeting, make sure clients and sponsors understand the nature and potential value of coaching, the nature and limits of confidentiality, financial arrangements and other terms of the agreement	Explain up front, to all parties
2	Create an agreement/contract on the roles, responsibilities and rights of all parties before services begin	No coaching before the agreement
3	Maintain the strictest confidentiality with all parties as agreed; comply with laws on personal data and communications	Confidentiality follows the agreement and the law
4	Have a clear understanding of how information is exchanged among all parties during coaching	Who gets told what, agreed in advance
5	Agree with clients and sponsors on when information will not be kept confidential: illegal activity, required by law, valid court order or subpoena, imminent or likely risk of danger to self or others; may need to inform authorities	The exceptions to confidentiality
6	As an Internal Coach, manage actual or potential conflicts of interest through agreements and ongoing dialogue, covering organizational roles, responsibilities, relationships, records, confidentiality and reporting	Internal coaching = built-in conflict risk; address it openly
7	Maintain, store and dispose of records (including electronic files) to protect confidentiality, security and privacy, complying with law; use technology-assisted coaching properly and know how the standards apply to it	Data protection; AI and tech tools used transparently
8	Stay alert to signs that the value of coaching is shifting; if so, change the relationship or encourage the client/sponsor to seek another coach, another professional or another resource	No progress over many sessions → step back and review the engagement
9	Respect all parties' right to end the coaching relationship at any point, for any reason, subject to the agreement	Client can always stop
10	Be sensitive to multiple contracts and relationships with the same client and sponsor at the same time, to avoid conflicts of interest	Coaching two peers, a boss and report, or a friend
11	Be aware of and actively manage any power or status difference between client and coach (cultural, relational, psychological, contextual)	Partnership of equals
12	Disclose to clients any compensation or other benefits for referring them to third parties	Referral fees must be disclosed
13	Assure consistent quality of coaching regardless of the amount or form of compensation	Pro bono gets the same quality

Section II – Responsibility to Practice and Performance (14–19)

#	THE STANDARD	EXAM ANGLE
14	Adhere to the Code in all interactions. When aware of a possible breach by yourself, or unethical behavior by another ICF Professional, respectfully raise the matter with those involved; if that doesn't resolve it, refer it to a formal authority (e.g., ICF Global)	Escalate in steps: private conversation first, formal complaint second
15	Require all Support Personnel to adhere to the Code	Assistants are bound too
16	Commit to excellence through continued personal, professional and ethical development	Lifelong learning, CCEs, mentoring, supervision
17	Recognize personal limitations or circumstances that may impair coaching; reach out for support, seek professional guidance if needed, which may include suspending or ending coaching	Coach overwhelmed, ill or distracted → get support, pause if needed
18	Resolve any actual or potential conflict of interest by working through it with relevant parties, seeking professional help, or suspending or ending the relationship	Disclose → work through → withdraw if unresolved
19	Maintain ICF Members' privacy; use member contact information only as authorized	No marketing to the member directory

Section III – Responsibility to Professionalism (20–24)

#	THE STANDARD	EXAM ANGLE
20	Accurately identify your coaching qualifications, competency level, expertise, experience, training, certifications and ICF Credentials	Never claim a credential you don't hold (e.g., "ACC" before it's awarded)
21	Make true and accurate statements about what you offer, what ICF offers, the coaching profession and the potential value of coaching	No guaranteed outcomes
22	Communicate and create awareness of the Code's ethical responsibilities with those who need to know	Tell clients and sponsors about the Code
23	Be aware of and set clear, appropriate and culturally sensitive boundaries for interactions, physical or otherwise	Coach owns the boundaries
24	No sexual or romantic engagement with clients or sponsors; stay mindful of the appropriate level of intimacy; take appropriate action or cancel the engagement	Applies to sponsors as well as clients

Section IV – Responsibility to Society (25–28)

#	THE STANDARD	EXAM ANGLE
25	Avoid discrimination by maintaining fairness and equality, respecting local rules and cultural practices (including age, race, gender expression, ethnicity, sexual orientation, religion, national origin, disability or military status)	Equal treatment for all

#	THE STANDARD	EXAM ANGLE
26	Recognize and honor others' contributions and intellectual property; claim ownership only of your own material	Credit tools and models you didn't create
27	Be honest and work within scientific standards and your competence when conducting and reporting research	Honest research
28	Be aware of your and your clients' impact on society; follow the philosophy of "doing good" versus "avoiding bad"	Positive contribution, not just harm avoidance

The five themes of the 2025 Code

The exam tests the 2020 Code above, but practice tests often use the wording of the 2025 Code (in force since April 1, 2025). It regroups the standards into five themed sections with 24 standards, so a question like "which ethical dimension is overlooked?" may expect one of these five names. The content is largely the same; the 2020 standards map onto them roughly as follows.

2025 SECTION	WHAT IT COVERS	MATCHING 2020 STANDARDS (APPROX.)	NEW IN 2025
1. Agreements for Client and/or Sponsor Engagement	Explaining coaching up front; agreements on roles, rights, fees, termination; right to end the relationship	1, 2, 9	–
2. Confidentiality and Legal Compliance	Confidentiality as agreed; how information flows; exceptions; records and data; laws	3, 4, 5, 7, 19	**2.5 Responsible use of AI and technology:** disclose AI tools (transcription, storage, analysis), who can access data, how long it's kept, how it's used; asking for consent is best practice
3. Professional Conduct and Conflicts of Interest	Conflicts of interest; internal coaching; multiple contracts; power differences; referral fees; boundaries; no romantic or sexual relationships	6, 10, 11, 12, 18, 23, 24	**3.7 Disclosure of multiple roles:** disclose when you hold more than one role with a client or their organization (coach and trainer, therapist, HR, mentor); stay in your role unless the client agrees to a change
4. Commitment to Delivering Consistent Value	Noticing when coaching stops adding value; consistent quality regardless of fee; ongoing development; recognizing personal limitations	8, 13, 16, 17	–
5. Professional Integrity and Accountability	Accurate claims about qualifications and coaching; raising breaches respectfully then formally; support personnel; non-discrimination; intellectual property; honest research; impact on society	14, 15, 20, 21, 22, 25, 26, 27, 28	–

The 2025 Code also adds a short section of **Commitments for All within the ICF Ecosystem** (staff, volunteers, members and credential holders), such as thinking globally, ongoing development, addressing bias and power dynamics, and seeking ethical guidance when needed.

> EXAM LINK
>
> A typical practice question where a coach avoided challenging a limiting belief to protect rapport expected "Commitment to delivering consistent value" – section 4 of the 2025 Code.

Sources: ICF – What you need to know about the 2025 Code · Erickson – What's new in the 2025 Code · CoachCert – Code updated, part 1

The situations the exam loves

In every ethics scenario the coach owns the ethical decision. Pick the answer that is the most **transparent, proportionate and protective**: name the issue, revisit agreements with all parties, refer or withdraw if it can't be resolved.

Confidentiality

- Confidentiality covers everything learned in the engagement unless the client consents to its release.
- What is shared, with whom and in what form is agreed at the start, with client and sponsor together (standards 1–5).
- Sponsors usually get **process** information (attendance, number of sessions, progress on agreed goals in general terms), not session **content**, unless the client agrees.
- Recognized exceptions, explained up front: illegal activity; requirement by law; valid court order or subpoena; imminent or likely danger to self or others.
- Records are stored securely and disposed of properly (standard 7). Discussing a case with a mentor or supervisor means removing identifying details.
- A coach who hears a colleague breach confidentiality speaks to the colleague privately first (standard 14).

Conflicts of interest

A conflict exists whenever serving one interest could work against another: financial, personal, relational or organizational.

SITUATION	WHY IT'S A CONFLICT	RIGHT MOVE
Coaching a close friend or family member	Personal relationship clouds objectivity	Decline and refer to another coach
Coaching two peers when one evaluates the other	Coach holds confidential info on both	Discuss with both; refer one if needed
Coaching a manager and their direct report	Overlapping confidentiality, loyalty pressure	Clarify boundaries and the conflict with all parties; refer if unresolved
Internal coach coaching someone they rate or influence	Dual role inside the organization	Disclose; manage through agreements; decline if it can't be managed
Selling another product or service to a client	Financial interest	Disclose; client's interest comes first
Earning a fee for referring a client	Hidden financial benefit	Disclose the fee (standard 12)
Sponsor asks for details of sessions	Sponsor vs. client interests	Go back to the agreed confidentiality terms; client consent needed

THE SEQUENCE

1	2	3	4	5
Be aware	Disclose openly	Work it through with relevant parties	Seek professional help	Suspend or end if unresolved

Three-way (sponsor) agreements

- The sponsor can help set goals and success measures for the engagement.
- The content of sessions stays between coach and client.
- Reporting (what, how often, who prepares it) is agreed by all three parties at the start; best practice is that the client shares progress with the sponsor, or is present when the coach does.
- When the sponsor's wishes and the client's agenda clash, the coach names the tension and revisits the agreement rather than siding with either.

Coaching minors

- Parents or guardians usually act as sponsors and give consent.
- Agree confidentiality with both the young client and the parent at the start, including what will be shared and the safety exceptions.
- When a parent asks for a recap, revisit the confidentiality agreement with both, rather than deciding alone or letting either one decide.
- Safeguarding concerns follow the law and local reporting requirements.

Unethical requests and ethical dilemmas

- When a client asks for help with something unethical (e.g., making a biased dismissal look legitimate), the coach says clearly that it conflicts with ethical standards and they can't support it.
- When an answer stays exploratory and avoids the ethical issue, it is wrong in an ethics question.
- Absolute answers ("never use tools", "always end the relationship") are usually wrong: ICF sets conditions, not bans.

Technology and AI

- Technology-assisted coaching is allowed (standard 7) with attention to privacy, data security and transparency.
- Disclose to clients when an AI tool or platform is used; the coach stays responsible for the coaching.
- Recording a session requires client consent.

Referral to therapy and other professionals

Coaching works with functioning clients moving forward. Refer when the client's needs fall outside coaching or the coach's competence.

Signs a client may need a mental health professional

From ICF's referral guidelines and common practice.

- Persistent sadness, hopelessness or loss of interest that doesn't lift
- Significant changes in sleep, appetite, energy or weight
- Anxiety, panic or fear that disrupts daily life
- Inability to function at work, at home or in relationships
- Talk of self-harm, suicide or harming others
- Substance misuse affecting life or the coaching
- Recurring trauma, intrusive memories or overwhelming emotions
- Extreme mood swings, paranoia, or a loss of touch with reality
- The same issue blocking progress session after session despite coaching

How to refer

1. Raise what you notice with care, in a private and respectful way.
2. Explain the difference between coaching and therapy and why another professional could help.
3. Offer options or resources; respect the client's choice.
4. Decide together whether coaching pauses, ends or continues in parallel with therapy (it can continue if the client is functioning and the topics are separate).
5. In an emergency or imminent risk, contact emergency services; safety overrides confidentiality.

> EXAM ANGLE
>
> Strong emotion alone (tears, grief, frustration) is not a reason to refer. Stay present. Refer when the issue blocks the client's ability to function or to progress, or there is risk.

Other referrals: legal, financial, medical or technical questions go to the relevant expert; the coach can still coach the client on acting on that expert's advice.

SECTION 6 · COMPETENCIES

The 8 Core Competencies (2019)

Eight competencies sit in four domains.

MEMORY AID FOR THE ORDER OF A SESSION

Who you are **(1–2)** → set it up **(3–5)** → the conversation **(6–7)** → land it **(8)**

A · FOUNDATION

1. Demonstrates Ethical Practice
2. Embodies a Coaching Mindset

B · CO-CREATING THE RELATIONSHIP

3. Establishes and Maintains Agreements
4. Cultivates Trust and Safety
5. Maintains Presence

C · COMMUNICATING EFFECTIVELY

6. Listens Actively
7. Evokes Awareness

D · CULTIVATING LEARNING AND GROWTH

8. Facilitates Client Growth

Each competency below gives ICF's definition and markers as published in the ICF Core Competencies (2019), followed by my own notes on the wrong-answer patterns to watch for.

1 Demonstrates Ethical Practice

DEFINITION

Understands and consistently applies coaching ethics and standards of coaching.

1. Demonstrates personal integrity and honesty in interactions with clients, sponsors and relevant stakeholders
2. Is sensitive to clients' identity, environment, experiences, values and beliefs
3. Uses language appropriate and respectful to clients, sponsors and relevant stakeholders
4. Abides by the ICF Code of Ethics and upholds the Core Values
5. Maintains confidentiality with client information per stakeholder agreements and pertinent laws
6. Maintains the distinctions between coaching, consulting, psychotherapy and other support professions
7. Refers clients to other support professionals, as appropriate

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Therapy-style interventions; sharing client details without agreement; ignoring signs a client needs another professional.

2 Embodies a Coaching Mindset

DEFINITION

Develops and maintains a mindset that is open, curious, flexible and client-centered.

1. Acknowledges that clients are responsible for their own choices
2. Engages in ongoing learning and development as a coach
3. Develops an ongoing reflective practice to enhance one's coaching
4. Remains aware of and open to the influence of context and culture on self and others
5. Uses awareness of self and one's intuition to benefit clients
6. Develops and maintains the ability to regulate one's emotions
7. Mentally and emotionally prepares for sessions
8. Seeks help from outside sources when necessary

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Coach feeling responsible for the outcome; pushing a preferred solution; ignoring their own reactions; no supervision or mentoring.

3 Establishes and Maintains Agreements

DEFINITION

Partners with the client and relevant stakeholders to create clear agreements about the coaching relationship, process, plans and goals. Establishes agreements for the overall coaching engagement as well as those for each coaching session.

1. Explains what coaching is and is not and describes the process to the client and relevant stakeholders
2. Reaches agreement about what is and is not appropriate in the relationship, what is and is not being offered, and the responsibilities of the client and relevant stakeholders
3. Reaches agreement about the guidelines and specific parameters of the coaching relationship such as logistics, fees, scheduling, duration, termination, confidentiality and inclusion of others
4. Partners with the client and relevant stakeholders to establish an overall coaching plan and goals
5. Partners with the client to determine client-coach compatibility
6. Partners with the client to identify or reconfirm what they want to accomplish in the session
7. Partners with the client to define what the client believes they need to address or resolve to achieve what they want to accomplish in the session
8. Partners with the client to define or reconfirm measures of success for what the client wants to accomplish in the coaching engagement or individual session

9. Partners with the client to manage the time and focus of the session
10. Continues coaching in the direction of the client's desired outcome unless the client indicates otherwise
11. Partners with the client to end the coaching relationship in a way that honors the experience

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Coach sets the topic; coaching starts before the client defines what they want; silently following a new topic instead of checking in; ignoring repeated lack of progress.

4 Cultivates Trust and Safety

DEFINITION

Partners with the client to create a safe, supportive environment that allows the client to share freely. Maintains a relationship of mutual respect and trust.

1. Seeks to understand the client within their context, which may include their identity, environment, experiences, values and beliefs
2. Demonstrates respect for the client's identity, perceptions, style and language and adapts one's coaching to the client
3. Acknowledges and respects the client's unique talents, insights and work in the coaching process
4. Shows support, empathy and concern for the client
5. Acknowledges and supports the client's expression of feelings, perceptions, concerns, beliefs and suggestions
6. Demonstrates openness and transparency as a way to display vulnerability and build trust with the client

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Judging or correcting feelings; generic praise instead of specific acknowledgment; reassurance that minimizes ("it's normal, it will pass"); forcing the coach's style or culture on the client.

5 Maintains Presence

DEFINITION

Is fully conscious and present with the client, employing a style that is open, flexible, grounded and confident.

1. Remains focused, observant, empathetic and responsive to the client
2. Demonstrates curiosity during the coaching process
3. Manages one's emotions to stay present with the client
4. Demonstrates confidence in working with strong client emotions during the coaching process
5. Is comfortable working in a space of not knowing
6. Creates or allows space for silence, pause or reflection

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Filling silence; moving to action when emotions appear; planning the next question while the client talks; “professional demeanor” (appears in no competency).

6 Listens Actively

DEFINITION

Focuses on what the client is and is not saying to fully understand what is being communicated in the context of the client systems and to support client self-expression.

1. Considers the client’s context, identity, environment, experiences, values and beliefs to enhance understanding of what the client is communicating
2. Reflects or summarizes what the client communicated to ensure clarity and understanding
3. Recognizes and inquires when there is more to what the client is communicating
4. Notices, acknowledges and explores the client’s emotions, energy shifts, non-verbal cues or other behaviors
5. Integrates the client’s words, tone of voice and body language to determine the full meaning of what is being communicated
6. Notices trends in the client’s behaviors and emotions across sessions to discern themes and patterns

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Passive listening (“let them speak uninterrupted”); summarizing with the coach’s interpretation; naming an emotion the client hasn’t named; ignoring tone or body language.

7 Evokes Awareness

DEFINITION

Facilitates client insight and learning by using tools and techniques such as powerful questioning, silence, metaphor or analogy.

1. Considers client experience when deciding what might be most useful
2. Challenges the client as a way to evoke awareness or insight
3. Asks questions about the client, such as their way of thinking, values, needs, wants and beliefs
4. Asks questions that help the client explore beyond current thinking
5. Invites the client to share more about their experience in the moment
6. Notices what is working to enhance client progress
7. Adjusts the coaching approach in response to the client’s needs
8. Helps the client identify factors that influence current and future patterns of behavior, thinking or emotion
9. Invites the client to generate ideas about how they can move forward and what they are willing or able to do

10. Supports the client in reframing perspectives
11. Shares observations, insights and feelings, without attachment, that have the potential to create new learning for the client

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Leading questions ("Don't you think...?"); stacked questions; advice disguised as a question; questions about the situation instead of the person; defending an observation the client rejects.

8 Facilitates Client Growth

DEFINITION

Partners with the client to transform learning and insight into action. Promotes client autonomy in the coaching process.

1. Works with the client to integrate new awareness, insight or learning into their worldview and behaviors
2. Partners with the client to design goals, actions and accountability measures that integrate and expand new learning
3. Acknowledges and supports client autonomy in the design of goals, actions and methods of accountability
4. Supports the client in identifying potential results or learning from identified action steps
5. Invites the client to consider how to move forward, including resources, support and potential barriers
6. Partners with the client to summarize learning and insight within or between sessions
7. Celebrates the client's progress and successes
8. Partners with the client to close the session

WRONG-ANSWER PATTERNS

Coach assigns homework; coach summarizes for the client; ending without exploring takeaways; staying in exploration after the client asks "what do I do now?"

Competency borders: which one is it?

Most competency mistakes come from behaviors that sit near a border. Match the specific behavior in the question to the sub-point it appears in.

BEHAVIOR IN THE QUESTION	COMPETENCY	NOT THIS ONE	HOW TO TELL
Responsive, flexible, focused in the moment	**5. Presence**	7. Evokes	Presence is the coach's state
Adjusting the coaching approach or technique	**7. Evokes**	5. Presence	Evokes is the coach's choice of tools
Silence as a deliberate tool to deepen thinking	**7. Evokes** (tools) / **5. Presence** (allows space)	Passive "letting them finish"	Silence is purposeful, not waiting
Inviting the client to generate ideas to move forward	**7. Evokes**	8. Growth	Creates options and insight
Integrating awareness into worldview and behavior	**8. Growth**	7. Evokes	Turns insight into change
Designing goals, actions, accountability	**8. Growth**	3. Agreements	Action from new learning
Agreeing what to work on today and how success looks	**3. Agreements**	8. Growth	Session contract, start of session
Closing the session	**8. Growth**	3. Agreements	Session close
Ending the relationship respectfully	**3. Agreements**	8. Growth	Engagement close
Checking client-coach compatibility	**3. Agreements**	4. Trust	Chemistry is part of contracting
Acknowledging the client's talents, effort, courage	**4. Trust and Safety**	8. Celebrates progress	Acknowledges who they are / what they did
Celebrating progress and successes	**8. Growth**	4. Trust	Results and steps forward
Noticing tone, energy shifts, body language	**6. Listens**	5. Presence	Picking up signals
Noticing patterns across sessions	**6. Listens**	7. Evokes	Spotting the pattern
Helping the client explore what drives a pattern	**7. Evokes**	6. Listens	Working with the pattern
Reflecting or summarizing what the client said	**6. Listens**	8. Growth	Ensures understanding
Client summarizes learning at the end	**8. Growth**	6. Listens	Consolidates learning

BEHAVIOR IN THE QUESTION	COMPETENCY	NOT THIS ONE	HOW TO TELL
Managing own emotions to stay with the client	**5. Presence**	2. Mindset	In the moment
Regulating emotions, preparing before sessions	**2. Mindset**	5. Presence	Ongoing practice / before the session
Reflective practice, supervision, mentoring	**2. Mindset**	1. Ethics	Coach's development
Referring to other professionals	**1. Ethics**	3. Agreements	Boundaries of coaching
Showing vulnerability and transparency	**4. Trust**	7. Evokes	Builds trust
Sharing an observation or feeling without attachment	**7. Evokes**	4. Trust	Aims at new learning

Timing rules that decide between two good answers

Client asks "what do I do now?" → move to action (8). Staying in exploration is wrong.

Client shares an insight but hasn't asked → acknowledge it, then bridge ("How might this affect what you do next?").

Client shares something vulnerable or a quiet breakthrough → acknowledge first (4/6), ask later.

Words and actions don't match → share the observation of the gap (7), then let the client respond.

Same goal stalls over many sessions → zoom out to the agreement and the value of coaching (3; standard 8).

Topic shifts mid-session → name the shift and ask where the client wants to focus (3).

Near the end of a session → don't open a new exploration; acknowledge and close (8).

Acknowledgment, praise, championing

MOVE	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE	ON THE EXAM
Acknowledgment	Recognizing who the client is being or what it took	"It took courage to say that."	Usually right
Praise	The coach's judgment that something is good	"Great job, excellent insight!"	Usually wrong
Championing	Expressing belief in the client when they doubt themselves	"I believe you can find a way through this."	Right when the client doubts themselves
Reassurance / normalizing	Minimizing the experience	"Everyone feels that way, it will pass."	Usually wrong

Observation versus interpretation

INTERPRETATION (AVOID)	OBSERVATION (PREFER)
“You seem anxious.”	“I notice your voice got quieter.”
“You’re not excited about this.”	“You said ‘great’ and paused before saying it.”
“This topic upsets you.”	“You looked away when you mentioned your team.”
“You’re afraid of the risks.”	“As you described the partnership, I noticed a tightness in my chest.”

THE FORMULA

I notice *[behavior]* → open question → the client names it.

Agreements, goal setting and motivation

Agreements exist at two levels: the whole engagement and each session. Questions often test which level an item belongs to.

Engagement agreement vs. session agreement

ENGAGEMENT (OVERALL) AGREEMENT	SESSION AGREEMENT
What coaching is and is not; the process	What the client wants to accomplish today
Roles, responsibilities and rights of coach, client, sponsor	Why it matters to them now
Logistics: fees, scheduling, location or platform, cancellations	How they'll know they got there (measures of success)
Duration and number of sessions; termination terms	What they believe they need to address or resolve
Confidentiality and its limits; how information is shared	Managing time and focus
Inclusion of others (sponsor, HR, manager) and reporting	Checking in when the focus shifts
Overall coaching plan and goals; compatibility	Closing the session

> KEY ELEMENTS OF A WRITTEN COACHING CONTRACT
>
> Parties, services, duration, fees and payment terms, cancellation policy, confidentiality and exceptions, record keeping, responsibilities of each party, termination by either party, reference to the ICF Code of Ethics, signatures.

Goal frameworks

- **SMART:** Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound.
- **Outcome, performance, process goals:** the end result (win the role) → the standard to reach (deliver 3 strong presentations) → the behaviors in the client's control (practice twice a week). Process goals are most within the client's control.
- **Approach vs. avoidance goals:** "become confident speaking up" vs. "stop being anxious". Approach goals sustain motivation better.
- **Intrinsic vs. extrinsic goals:** goals linked to personal values hold better than goals driven by rewards or pressure.
- **Stretch goals:** challenging but reachable; the coach may make a request bigger than the client would choose, and the client decides.
- **Learning goals** (build a capability) vs. **performance goals** (hit a result).

Motivation theories

THEORY	AUTHOR	CORE IDEA	COACHING USE
Self-Determination Theory	Deci & Ryan	Motivation thrives when 3 needs are met: autonomy, competence, relatedness; intrinsic beats extrinsic	Why client autonomy matters
Self-efficacy	Bandura	Belief in one's ability to succeed at a specific task, built mainly by mastery experiences (also role models, encouragement, managing stress)	Small wins build confidence
Growth mindset	Dweck	Abilities can be developed (growth) vs. are fixed (fixed)	Reframing setbacks as learning
Stages of Change (Transtheoretical Model)	Prochaska & DiClemente	Precontemplation → Contemplation → Preparation → Action → Maintenance (relapse is normal)	Match the approach to the stage
Hierarchy of needs	Maslow	Physiological → safety → belonging → esteem → self-actualization	Lower needs first
Expectancy theory	Vroom	Motivation = expectancy × instrumentality × valence	Do they believe effort pays off and value the result?
Goal-setting theory	Locke & Latham	Specific, challenging goals with feedback raise performance	Clear, stretching goals
Two-factor theory	Herzberg	Motivators (achievement, growth) vs. hygiene factors (pay, conditions)	Job satisfaction topics

Stages of Change in more detail

STAGE	CLIENT SOUNDS LIKE	COACHING FOCUS
Precontemplation	"I don't see a problem."	Raise awareness, curiosity; no action plans
Contemplation	"I'm thinking about it, but I'm not sure."	Explore ambivalence, pros and cons, values
Preparation	"I'm going to start next month."	Plan, small first steps
Action	"I've started."	Support, accountability, celebrate progress
Maintenance	"I've kept it up for months."	Sustain, prevent relapse
Relapse	"I slipped back."	Normalize as learning, re-enter the cycle

Accountability

- The client designs what they'll do, by when, and how they'll be accountable; the coach partners.
- The coach doesn't assign homework; the client may choose "fieldwork" or practices.
- Missed commitments are explored with curiosity, not judgment: what got in the way, what was learned, what's next.
- Accountability can be to the coach, to a peer, to a tracker, or to self.

Models, tools and techniques

The exam expects you to recognize the main coaching models and tools by name, know what each is for, and know that the client stays in charge of how any tool is used.

Coaching conversation models

MODEL	AUTHOR	STEPS	USE
GROW	Whitmore (*Coaching for Performance*)	Goal → Reality → Options → Will / Way forward	The most cited session structure
OSKAR	Jackson & McKergow (solution-focused)	Outcome → Scaling → Know-how → Affirm & action → Review	Builds on what already works
CLEAR	Hawkins	Contract → Listen → Explore → Action → Review	Starts with contracting
Co-Active Model	Kimsey-House & Whitworth	4 cornerstones, 3 areas of focus, 5 contexts	Classic life-coaching framework
Appreciative Inquiry (4-D)	Cooperrider	Discover → Dream → Design → Destiny (Deliver)	Strengths-based change
Kolb learning cycle	Kolb	Concrete experience → Reflective observation → Abstract conceptualization → Active experimentation	Turning experience into learning
Bridges Transition Model	Bridges	Ending → Neutral Zone → New Beginning	Inner process of change (career change, divorce, relocation)

Co-Active Model in detail

- **Cornerstones:** people are naturally creative, resourceful and whole; focus on the whole person; dance in this moment; evoke transformation.
- **Areas of focus:** Fulfillment (living by values), Balance (perspective and choice), Process (being with what the client experiences now).
- **Contexts (coach skills):** listening, intuition, curiosity, forward and deepen, self-management.
- **Three levels of listening:** Level 1 internal (the coach's own thoughts – avoid); Level 2 focused (fully on the client); Level 3 global (energy, mood, what's unsaid in the space).

Solution-focused techniques

TECHNIQUE	EXAMPLE QUESTION
Miracle question	"If a miracle happened overnight and this was solved, what would you notice first?"
Exception question	"When is this problem less present? What's different then?"

TECHNIQUE	EXAMPLE QUESTION
Scaling question	“From 1 to 10, where are you now? What would one point higher look like?”
Coping question	“Given how hard this has been, how have you kept going?”
Preferred future	“What would you like to be different?”

Questioning skills

- **Powerful questions:** open, short, one at a time, about the client, forward-moving.
- **“What” and “How” over “Why”:** “why” can feel judgmental (“What led to that?” instead).
- **“What else?”** goes beyond the first answer.
- **Closed questions** are fine for confirming facts or agreements.
- **Avoid:** leading questions (“Wouldn’t it be better to…?”), stacked questions, advice disguised as a question (“Have you tried…?”), “why” questions that blame.
- **Clean Language (David Grove):** questions using only the client’s own words and metaphors, e.g. “And what kind of stuck is that stuck?”
- **Metaphor and analogy:** work with the client’s images (“I feel like I’m drowning”) instead of imposing the coach’s.

Communication skills

SKILL	WHAT IT DOES
Reflecting / mirroring	Repeats key words or emotion back so the client hears themselves
Paraphrasing	Restates the meaning in other words
Summarizing	Condenses several points to check understanding
Bottom-lining	Invites the client to get to the essence
Intruding / interrupting	Respectfully redirects a client lost in story, for the client’s benefit
Direct communication	Clear, concise feedback or observation
Reframing	Offers a new perspective on the same situation
Silence	Gives space to think and feel
Requests and challenges	Invites a specific action; a challenge stretches beyond what the client would choose; client can say yes, no or counter-offer
Holding space	Stays present without fixing
Somatic awareness	Notices body signals (client’s or coach’s) and offers them without attachment

Life-coaching and self-awareness tools

TOOL	PURPOSE	COACH'S ROLE
Wheel of Life	Client rates satisfaction 1–10 across life areas (career, health, relationships, money, fun, growth, environment)	Client interprets and chooses the focus; lowest score isn't automatically the priority
Values clarification	Identifies core values via peak moments or frustrations	Client names the values
Strengths assessments	VIA Character Strengths, CliftonStrengths	Builds on strengths
Personality assessments	MBTI, DISC, Enneagram, Big Five	Only if the coach is qualified/certified and it serves the client's agenda
Visualization / future self	Client pictures a desired future or each option's outcome	Helps access the client's own sense
Johari Window	Open / Blind / Hidden / Unknown self	Working on blind spots through feedback
ABC(DE) model	Ellis: Activating event → Belief → Consequence → Dispute → Effective new belief	Beliefs, not events, drive reactions
Limiting beliefs work	Surfaces assumptions ("I'm too old to change careers")	Explore with questions, don't contradict
Immunity to Change	Kegan & Lahey: goal → what you do instead → hidden competing commitment → big assumption	When clients don't change despite wanting to
360-degree feedback	Input from manager, peers, reports	Mostly executive coaching; agree confidentiality first

Positive psychology

- **PERMA (Seligman):** Positive emotion, Engagement, Relationships, Meaning, Accomplishment.
- **Flow (Csikszentmihalyi):** full absorption in a task where challenge matches skill.
- **Strengths-based coaching:** builds on what works rather than fixing weaknesses.
- **Broaden-and-build (Fredrickson):** positive emotions widen thinking and build resources.

Motivational Interviewing (MI)

- **OARS:** Open questions, Affirmations, Reflections, Summaries.
- **Ambivalence is normal;** draw out the client's own reasons for change (change talk) rather than arguing for change.
- **Roll with resistance:** explore it with curiosity instead of pushing back.

Cognitive-behavioral coaching

Based on CBT ideas, used with non-clinical clients: examining thoughts, beliefs and behaviors, testing assumptions, building new habits. The coach doesn't treat disorders.

SECTION 10 · GLOSSARY

Glossary A–Z

These terms come from the wider coaching and psychology literature that prep tests and the ACC reference books draw on. When two look alike, pick the one matching the scenario's most specific detail.

ACC Minimum Skills Requirements
The ICF criteria for what an ACC-level coaching session must show, assessed on the recorded performance evaluation

Acknowledgment
Recognizing who the client is being or what it took; not the coach's judgment

Active listening
Interactive listening: reflecting words, emotion, tone, assumptions, and what isn't said

Ambivalence
Wanting and not wanting change at the same time; normal in change

Appreciative inquiry
Strengths-based approach: Discover, Dream, Design, Destiny

Bias, unconscious
Automatic attitudes that shape judgment without awareness

Blind spot
What others see about us that we don't (Johari Window)

Bottom-lining
Inviting the client to state the essence

CCE (Continuing Coach Education)
Learning units required to renew a credential

Championing
Expressing belief in the client when they doubt themselves

Chemistry session
A first meeting to check coach–client fit

Coaching supervision
A reflective space for the coach's development, wellbeing and ethical practice

Cognitive dissonance
Discomfort from a gap between beliefs and actions

Competency
A cluster of knowledge, skills and behaviors needed to coach effectively

Confidentiality
Protecting information from the engagement unless the client consents to release

Conflict of interest
Multiple interests where serving one could work against another

Countertransference
The coach projecting their own feelings onto the client; a signal for supervision

Cultural competence
Knowledge and skills for working across cultures

Cultural humility
Ongoing openness and self-critique about one's own cultural lens

Dual relationship
Holding two roles with the same person (coach and friend, coach and manager)

Emotional intelligence
Goleman: self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, social skills

Empathy
Understanding and sharing another's feelings without taking them over

Equality
Same treatment and access for all

Equity
Fairness according to need, so everyone can reach equality

Extrinsic motivation
Driven by outside reward or pressure

Fieldwork
Actions or practices the client chooses between sessions

Fixed mindset
Belief that abilities are fixed

Flow
Full absorption where challenge matches skill

Group coaching
Individuals with their own goals coached in a group

Growth mindset
Belief that abilities can be developed

Holding space
Staying present without fixing

Imposter phenomenon
Feeling like a fraud despite evidence of competence

Inclusive mindset
Actively applying awareness so all voices are recognized, valued and integrated

Internal coach
Employee who coaches others in the same organization

Internal / external locus of control
Belief that outcomes are shaped by one's actions vs. by outside forces

Intrinsic motivation
Driven by inner reward, values, interest

Intuition
Inner sense the coach offers without attachment for the client's benefit

Learned helplessness
Giving up after repeated failure, believing effort won't matter

Limiting belief
An assumption that holds the client back

Mentor coaching
Coaching on one's coaching skills against the Core Competencies; 10 hours required for ACC

Metaphor
The client's image for their experience, used to explore it

Mindfulness
Non-judgmental attention to the present moment

Neuroplasticity
The brain's ability to form new pathways, supporting habit change

Optimism bias
Overestimating positive outcomes regardless of ability

Paraphrasing
Restating meaning in different words

Powerful question
Open, short, client-focused question that evokes new thinking

Psychological safety
Edmondson: feeling safe to take interpersonal risks

Rapport
Mutual trust and connection

Reflective practice
The coach regularly reviewing their own work to learn

Reframing
Seeing the same situation from a new angle

Resilience
Ability to recover from setbacks

Self-awareness
Knowing one's own thoughts, emotions, values and impact

Self-confidence
General belief in one's abilities

Self-efficacy
Belief in one's ability to succeed at a specific task, built by past mastery

Self-esteem
General sense of self-worth

Self-management
The coach setting aside their own opinions and reactions

Somatic awareness
Noticing body signals as information

Sponsor
Entity paying for, arranging or defining the coaching

Stakeholder
Anyone with an interest in the coaching outcome (manager, HR, sponsor)

Support personnel
People working for the coach in support of clients

Systemic equality
Equality built into policies, structures and cultures

Team coaching
Coaching a team as a system toward a shared goal

Three-way contract
Agreement between coach, client and sponsor

Transference
The client projecting feelings from past relationships onto the coach

Values
What matters most to the client; drives fulfillment

Confusable pairs at a glance

PAIR	DIFFERENCE
Self-efficacy vs. self-esteem	Task-specific capability vs. general worth
Inclusive mindset vs. cultural competence	Active practice vs. knowledge
Equity vs. equality	Fair according to need vs. the same for all
Mentor coaching vs. supervision	Skill feedback vs. reflective support for the coach
Team vs. group coaching	One shared goal vs. individual goals in a group
Acknowledgment vs. praise	About the client vs. the coach's judgment
Client vs. sponsor	Person coached vs. entity paying or arranging
Transference vs. countertransference	Client projects onto coach vs. coach onto client
Change vs. transition (Bridges)	The outer event vs. the inner process

SECTION 11 · EXAM DAY

Answer rules and common mistakes

Most practice-test misses fall into a handful of patterns. Read these rules the night before and again before the exam starts.

Ten answer rules

01 **The client owns the content; the coach owns the process and the ethics.** Pick the answer that keeps each in the right hands.

02 **Acknowledge before you ask.** After a vulnerable moment or a quiet breakthrough, recognition comes first.

03 **Observe, don't interpret.** If an option names an emotion, cause or meaning the client hasn't stated, be suspicious.

04 **Name the gap.** When words and actions don't match, share the observation plainly and let the client respond.

05 **Ask about the person, not the situation.** Beliefs, values and identity beat facts and events.

06 **Read the client's cue.** "What do I do now?" means action; an insight without that cue means bridge, not plan.

07 **Stalled for many sessions? Zoom out.** Revisit the agreement and the value of coaching.

08 **Ethics: transparent, proportionate, protective.** Name the issue; revisit agreements with all parties; refer or withdraw if it can't be resolved; speak privately before escalating.

09 **Watch for absolutes.** "Never", "always" and outright bans are usually wrong; ICF sets conditions.

10 **Generic professional language is a trap.** "Professional demeanor", "informed perspectives" or "praise" don't appear in the competencies.

WHEN TWO ANSWERS BOTH LOOK GOOD

Check each against these four questions. The one that passes all four is almost always correct.

1. Does it assume anything the client hasn't said?
2. Is it about the client and the present, or the situation and the past?
3. Is the coach actively engaging, or only being polite or passive?
4. Does it keep choices and conclusions with the client?

Exam-day tips

- 39 minutes per 30 questions is about 75 seconds per question; flag and move on if stuck.
- Answer every question: there is no penalty for guessing.
- Read the last line of the question first: "What should the coach do first?" or "Which competency...?" changes the answer.
- Eliminate the two clearly wrong options, then apply the four checks above.

AFTER THE EXAM

The exam tests what you know. Coaching is what you do with it.

Every rule in this guide comes back to the same idea: the client owns the content, the coach owns the process. That is as true on exam day as it is in session.

Want a thinking partner?

I coach entrepreneurs and leaders on getting their thoughts in order, setting a standard worth meeting, and committing to action that survives a bad month. If something in your work or life needs talking through properly, let's talk.

Book a discovery session · chernyakov-coaching.com

About this guide. I wrote this while preparing for my own ICF ACC exam. The summaries, exam angles, memory aids and answer rules are my own; ICF definitions, Code wording and Core Competency markers are quoted from ICF's published documents and credited where they appear.

Sources. ICF Code of Ethics (2020); ICF Code of Ethics (2025); ICF Core Competencies (2019); ICF, "What you need to know about the 2025 ICF Code of Ethics"; Erickson Coaching International, "What's new in the 2025 ICF Code of Ethics"; CoachCert, "ICF Code of Ethics updated, part 1". Models and theories are credited to their authors in the tables where they appear.

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I'm a coach, not a clinician. Nothing here is therapy or medical advice.